

“THE PARADIGM OF SECURITY SOLUTIONS IS CONSERVATIVE IN ITSELF”

Joerg Simon,
Fedora Security Lab creator



Open source is making things easier for security professionals. But choosing software to check vulnerabilities still seems difficult for many developers. **Jagmeet Singh of OSFY** spoke to **Fedora fellow, Joerg Simon**, who created Fedora Security Spin, to discuss the evolution of community-backed solutions in the world of penetration testing and security assessment. Edited excerpts...

Q What was the idea behind creating the Fedora Security Lab?

The original idea behind developing Fedora Security Lab (FSL) was to provide the same security tools and security related software that we maintain in Fedora as a ready-to-go, official Fedora security related release. Besides the official spin, we created a package group for the Fedora repositories to have it bundled with the Fedora installations and to provide the group install feature.

It was just a technical showcase of Fedora security features and tools, in the beginning. But today, the same group is involved in a small sub-project of its own.

Initially, I wanted to have FSL for teaching students and giving talks on security along with my favourite Security Test Platform. But something was missing — the targets to test.

You cannot just test in the wild, without penalties. Help came from my co-maintainer, Fabian Affolter. He created

the ‘Fedora Security Lab Test Bench’ that provides the counterpart to the original FSL, and lets you use it in a classroom environment on targets with built-in limitations.

It was very clear from the beginning that FSL, as a platform for professional security testers, can only be a starting point. To fill this gap without violating any Fedora guidelines, we also provide playbooks to simplify the installation process of tools with a very fast development cycle, and to add more features.

Q Vulnerabilities in software often grab the headlines. How can open source software help design an effective security solution?

The paradigm of security solutions is conservative in itself. Security solutions, as we know them today, often fail because they focus on threads derived from risks, which are dynamic. Instead, they should focus on the assets first.